by the light of a lamp lit in a human skull, burning human fat while strewing human teeth upon the dead body. At this, writes Abul Fazl, ‘if the heart of the necromancer does not fail him, the corpse begins to move’. Shiv Dat had made all the arrangements and left the corpse at a tanner’s house. As it happens, the baital arrived before the brahmin’s return, and told the tanner that the current ‘oppressors’ would be succeeded by Kayasths, then Muslims, and finally, at the eighth generation of Chak rulers, there would come one whose ‘thoughts, actions and speech are devoted to the accomplishment of the Divine Will’. *The Akbarnama of Abu’l Fazl*, vol. 3.

. Srivastava, *A Short History of Akbar the Great (1542–1605)*.

. P.P. Sinha, *Raja Birbal: Life and Times* (Janaki Prakashan, 1980).

. See Prasad, ‘Akbar and the Jains’. The monk went on: ‘Thieves and robbers were conspicuous by their absence in his empire. His glory was as white as the moon because he had defeated all his enemies. His religious zeal never made him intolerant.’

Akbar seems to have held the Jains in equally high esteem. A Sanskrit inscription on the Adiswara temple in Kathiawar, Gujarat, is quoted by Monserrate’s editors to demonstrate the Jains’ achievements in Akbar’s court. The inscription records how, in 1582, a Jain teacher called Hiravijaya persuaded Sahi Akbbara ‘to issue an edict forbidding the slaughter of animals for six months, to abolish the confiscation of the property of deceased persons, the Sujijia tax (the Jizia) and a Sulka, to set free many captives, snared birds and animals, to present Satrunjaya to the Jainas, to establish a Jaina library, and to become a saint like King Srenika (Bimbasara c. 582–554 BC)’. See editors’ introduction to Monserrate, *The Commentary of Father Monserrate*.

. Allison Busch, ‘Portrait of a Raja in a Badshah’s World: Amrit Rai’s Biography of Man Singh (1585)’, *Journal of the Economic and Social History of the Orient*, vol. 55, 2012.

.Azfar Moin, *The Millennial Sovereign: Sacred Kingship & Sainthood in Islam* (Columbia University Press, 2012).

. Ibid.

. Faruqui, ‘The Forgotten Prince’.

. Translator’s note in *The Ain-i-Akbari*, vol. 1.

.In this reply, Man Singh may also have explained, succinctly if unwittingly, the difficulty that the Jesuit Fathers, far from court, would face in finding converts. Akbar had long promised the various Jesuit missions that came to him that the Fathers would be free to live and proselytize in his realm, but it was clearly not an easy promise to keep – Akbar only issued a farman to this effect in 1602, two decades after the first Jesuit mission arrived in Fatehpur. It was also in 1602, shortly before the edict was issued, that the third Jesuit mission tells a story of conversion in Lahore, which sheds some light on the troubles the Fathers faced in recruiting a new flock in Hindustan.

It all began when a young brahmin pandit in Lahore was convinced by Father Pigneiro to adopt the Christian faith. The pandit’s family was terribly upset (as the Fathers write, ‘the Brachmanes, who are, more than all others given to idolatry, exhibited the greater resentment when any of their children became Christians’). The whole clan arrived to take their son back home, the pandit’s mother throwing herself at his feet, while the young man waved a sword above his head (‘he was . . . new to the teaching of our Saviour,’ write the Fathers, and hadn’t quite grasped Christ’s message of non-violence). Eventually, the family left, with the pandit’s mother flinging her grandchild upon the steps of the church in despair. A few days later, when his clan came back, the pandit flung his janeu at his mother in return, and cut off his topknot. At their wits’ end, the family complained to the sadr of Lahore, accusing Father Pigneiro of eating human flesh, stealing children, and practising black magic. The sadr was unable to bring about any peace between the two parties, so the pandit was taken to a Hindu ‘Coxi’, possibly ‘qazi’, judge. Thousands lined the streets of Lahore and peered from balconies, ‘many having shut up their shops that they might come and see what was taking place’.